

WARRIOR'S PATH

A PTSD Recovery Workbook for Veterans

Evidence-Based Tools for Healing
After Military Service

Cognitive Processing Therapy Worksheets
Grounding Techniques for Hypervigilance
Weekly Symptom Tracking
Reintegration & Moral Injury Work

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You served with honor. You deserve to heal.

Warrior's Path

A PTSD Recovery Workbook for Veterans

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IMPORTANT DISCLAIMER

This workbook is designed as a supplemental tool for PTSD recovery.

It is NOT a replacement for professional mental health treatment.

**If you are in crisis, contact the Veterans Crisis Line: 988 (Press 1)
or text 838255.**

This workbook incorporates evidence-based techniques from:

- Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT)
- Prolonged Exposure (PE) principles
- Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR)
- Imagery Rehearsal Therapy (IRT)

Dedicated to all who served and carry invisible wounds.

Your courage didn't end when your service did.

UNDERSTANDING COMBAT PTSD

WHAT IS PTSD?

Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder is a normal response to abnormal events. Your brain is doing exactly what it was trained to do: stay alert, anticipate threats, and protect you. The problem is that these responses are now activating in situations where there is no actual danger.

PREVALENCE IN VETERANS:

- 11-20% of veterans from Iraq/Afghanistan develop PTSD
- 12% of Gulf War veterans have PTSD in a given year
- 15% of Vietnam veterans were diagnosed with PTSD at time of study
- You are NOT alone. Millions of veterans share this experience.

PTSD IS NOT WEAKNESS

Just as a physical injury from combat requires medical treatment, a psychological injury requires care. PTSD is not a character flaw. It is not cowardice. It is a wound that needs healing.

Reflect: What has PTSD cost you? What would healing give back?

TRAUMA RESPONSE TYPES IN MILITARY CONTEXT

Your nervous system developed survival responses during service. Understanding them helps you recognize when they activate inappropriately in civilian life.

FIGHT Response:

Aggression, confrontation, rage outbursts, road rage, verbal attacks

In combat: necessary for survival and mission completion

In civilian life: damaged relationships, legal trouble, isolation

FLIGHT Response:

Avoidance, substance use, workaholism, constant busyness

In combat: tactical withdrawal, strategic repositioning

In civilian life: avoiding crowds, isolating, numbing with alcohol

FREEZE Response:

Shutdown, dissociation, numbness, inability to act or feel

In combat: playing dead, waiting for the right moment to act

In civilian life: emotional flatness, feeling disconnected from family

FAWN Response:

People-pleasing, inability to say no, loss of identity

In combat: following orders without question for unit cohesion

In civilian life: losing yourself to keep the peace, no boundaries

HYPERVIGILANCE:

Always scanning for threats. Sitting with back to the wall. Checking exits.

Startling at loud noises. Difficulty relaxing even in safe environments.

My primary trauma response is: _____

It shows up most in these situations:

MY VETERAN SAFETY PLAN

Complete this plan NOW, while you are calm. When crisis hits, you won't be able to think clearly - this plan does the thinking for you.

VETERANS CRISIS LINE: 988 (Press 1) | Text: 838255 | Chat: [VeteransCrisisLine.net](https://www.veteranscrisisline.net)

1. WARNING SIGNS (What tells me a crisis is building?):

? _____
? _____
? _____

2. MY BATTLE BUDDY (who I can call anytime):

Name: _____ Phone: _____

Name: _____ Phone: _____

3. INTERNAL COPING (things I can do alone):

? _____
? _____
? _____

4. SAFE PLACES I CAN GO:

5. PROFESSIONAL SUPPORT:

VA Therapist: _____ Phone: _____

Vet Center: _____ Phone: _____

Chaplain: _____ Phone: _____

6. MAKING MY ENVIRONMENT SAFE:

Firearms secured: Yes / No Location of safe storage: _____

Medications secured: Yes / No Alcohol removed: Yes / No

7. MY REASON TO STAY:

GROUNDING TECHNIQUES FOR HYPERVIGILANCE

When your threat detection system is in overdrive, these techniques bring you back to the present moment and signal SAFETY to your nervous system.

5-4-3-2-1 SENSORY GROUNDING:

5 things I can SEE: _____

4 things I can TOUCH: _____

3 things I can HEAR: _____

2 things I can SMELL: _____

1 thing I can TASTE: _____

TACTICAL BREATHING (Box Breathing - adapted from combat breathing):

1. Inhale through nose: 4 counts (like taking cover)

2. Hold: 4 counts (steady your position)

3. Exhale through mouth: 4 counts (controlled release)

4. Hold empty: 4 counts (reset)

Repeat 4-6 cycles. This activates your parasympathetic nervous system.

ORIENTING TO SAFETY:

1. Slowly look around the room. Name what you see out loud.

2. Identify evidence of safety: locked doors, familiar objects, time/date.

3. Say: 'I am [name]. I am in [place]. It is [year]. I am safe.'

4. Feel your feet on the ground. Press your back into the chair.

5. Hold something cold (ice cube) or textured (keys, coin).

MY GO-TO GROUNDING TECHNIQUES (write what works best for you):

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

TRIGGER MAPPING

Identifying triggers is the first step to managing them. Rate intensity 1-10.

SOUND TRIGGERS

Trigger	Intensity	My Coping Plan
Fireworks/explosions:	___ /10	_____
Helicopters/aircraft:	___ /10	_____
Loud bangs/backfires:	___ /10	_____
Yelling/arguing:	___ /10	_____

SMELL TRIGGERS

Trigger	Intensity	My Coping Plan
Diesel fuel/exhaust:	___ /10	_____
Burning/smoke:	___ /10	_____
Specific foods:	___ /10	_____
Other:	___ /10	_____

SITUATION TRIGGERS

Trigger	Intensity	My Coping Plan
Crowded places:	___ /10	_____
Driving (especially overpasses/debris):	___ /10	_____
Being startled from behind:	___ /10	_____
Confined spaces:	___ /10	_____

OTHER TRIGGERS I'VE IDENTIFIED:

Trigger: _____ Intensity: ___/10

Coping plan: _____

Trigger: _____ Intensity: ___/10

Coping plan: _____

Trigger: _____ Intensity: ___/10

Coping plan: _____

Trigger: _____ Intensity: ___/10

Coping plan: _____

STUCK POINT #1

"It was my fault."

Many veterans blame themselves for events outside their control.

CHALLENGING THIS STUCK POINT:

What was actually within your control in that situation?

What would you say to a fellow service member who said this?

What training/orders/chaos factors were at play?

Rewrite this belief with the evidence:

Belief strength BEFORE this exercise: ____/100

Belief strength AFTER this exercise: ____/100

STUCK POINT #2

"I should have done more."

Survivor's guilt is common. You did what you could with what you had.

CHALLENGING THIS STUCK POINT:

What DID you do? List your actions in that moment:

Given the information you had at the time (not now), what was possible?

Would you judge a squad mate this harshly for the same actions?

A more balanced thought:

Belief strength BEFORE this exercise: ____/100

Belief strength AFTER this exercise: ____/100

STUCK POINT #3

"The world is dangerous."

Your brain learned this in a war zone. It was true THERE. Is it true HERE?

CHALLENGING THIS STUCK POINT:

List 5 safe moments from the past week:

What percentage of your day involves actual threat? (be honest)

What evidence do you have that you are safe right now?

A more balanced thought:

Belief strength BEFORE this exercise: ____/100

Belief strength AFTER this exercise: ____/100

STUCK POINT #4

"I can't trust anyone."

Betrayal and loss in combat make trust feel impossible.

CHALLENGING THIS STUCK POINT:

Who has shown up for you, even in small ways?

What is the difference between healthy caution and total isolation?

What is one small trust you could extend this week?

A more balanced thought:

Belief strength BEFORE this exercise: ____/100

Belief strength AFTER this exercise: ____/100

STUCK POINT #5

"I don't deserve good things."

Moral injury and guilt can convince you that you deserve punishment.

CHALLENGING THIS STUCK POINT:

If you don't deserve good things, why do you want them for others?

What would your service mean if you never allowed yourself peace?

What have you done since service that shows your character?

A more balanced thought:

Belief strength BEFORE this exercise: ____/100

Belief strength AFTER this exercise: ____/100

ANGER MANAGEMENT FOR VETERANS

In the military, controlled aggression was a tool. In civilian life, that same intensity can destroy relationships, careers, and freedom.

THE ANGER ESCALATION LADDER:

- 10 - Violence / Destruction (point of no return)
- 8 - Yelling, threatening, slamming things
- 6 - Raised voice, clenched fists, pacing
- 4 - Irritation, short responses, muscle tension
- 2 - Mild annoyance, restlessness
- 0 - Calm baseline

MY EARLY WARNING SIGNS (catch it at 2-4, not 8-10):

Physical: _____

Thoughts: _____

Behaviors: _____

TACTICAL PAUSE PROTOCOL:

1. STOP - Recognize the activation. Say 'I need a tactical pause.'
2. STEP BACK - Physically remove yourself for 20 minutes minimum.
3. BREATHE - Use tactical breathing (4-4-4-4 box breathing).
4. THINK - What am I actually angry about? Is this threat real?
5. RETURN - Come back when at 2-3, not 0 (that takes longer).

ANGER LOG - Track your episodes this week:

Date | Trigger | Level (0-10) | What I Did | What I Wish I Did

SLEEP & NIGHTMARES PROTOCOL

Sleep disturbance is one of the most common and debilitating PTSD symptoms.
Your brain keeps you on guard duty even when you need rest.

SLEEP HYGIENE FOR PTSD:

- ? Set a consistent wake time (more important than bedtime)
- ? Create a 'stand down' routine: dim lights 1 hour before bed
- ? No screens 30 min before sleep (blue light = alertness signal)
- ? Make bedroom feel SAFE: nightlight OK, door locks checked, clear sightlines
- ? No caffeine after 1400 hours
- ? Exercise daily but not within 3 hours of bedtime
- ? If not asleep in 20 min, get up - bed is for sleep only

IMAGERY REHEARSAL THERAPY (IRT) for Nightmares:

Step 1: Write down your recurring nightmare (brief):

Step 2: Now REWRITE the ending. You are in control. Change it:

Step 3: Practice visualizing the NEW ending for 10 min before sleep.

NIGHTMARE LOG:

Date | Content (brief) | Intensity 1-10 | IRT Practiced?

REINTEGRATION CHALLENGES

Adjusting to Civilian Life

The transition from military to civilian life is one of the biggest adjustments you'll ever make. It's OK to struggle with it.

RATE YOUR CHALLENGE AREAS (1=managing well, 10=major struggle):

- ___/10 Loss of structure/routine
- ___/10 Loss of mission/purpose
- ___/10 Relating to civilians who 'don't get it'
- ___/10 Family relationships
- ___/10 Finding meaningful employment
- ___/10 Financial management
- ___/10 Making decisions without chain of command
- ___/10 Social isolation
- ___/10 Feeling like I don't belong anywhere
- ___/10 Missing my unit/brothers/sisters

TOP 3 CHALLENGES I WANT TO WORK ON:

1. Challenge: _____
One small step I can take this week: _____
Who can help me with this: _____
2. Challenge: _____
One small step I can take this week: _____
Who can help me with this: _____
3. Challenge: _____
One small step I can take this week: _____
Who can help me with this: _____

THINGS I MISS ABOUT SERVICE:

CIVILIAN EQUIVALENT I CAN BUILD:

MORAL INJURY EXPLORATION

Moral injury occurs when you participated in, witnessed, or failed to prevent events that conflict with your deeply held moral beliefs and values.
This is different from PTSD - it's a wound to the soul, not just the mind.

UNDERSTANDING MORAL INJURY:

- Things I did that conflict with my values
- Things I failed to do (acts of omission)
- Things I witnessed that shattered my worldview
- Betrayal by leadership or the system

WITHOUT NAMING SPECIFIC EVENTS (unless you choose to):

What value of mine was violated? _____

What emotion comes up most? (shame/guilt/anger/betrayal/grief)

CONTEXT THAT MATTERS:

What were the circumstances? (war, orders, split-second decisions, fog of war)

SELF-COMPASSION:

Would you condemn a fellow veteran who did the same thing? Yes / No

What would you say to them? _____

MOVING FORWARD:

What act of repair, service, or meaning-making could help? (not penance)

BUILDING PURPOSE POST-SERVICE

Identity Beyond the Uniform

When your identity was built around service, who are you without it?

The answer: you are the VALUES behind the uniform, not the uniform itself.

MILITARY VALUES I STILL CARRY:

? Loyalty: How I can express this now: _____

? Duty: How I can express this now: _____

? Integrity: How I can express this now: _____

? Service to others: How I can express this now: _____

? Discipline: How I can express this now: _____

? Courage: How I can express this now: _____

STRENGTHS FROM MY SERVICE:

Skills I developed: _____

Character traits forged: _____

What I'm proud of: _____

NEW MISSION STATEMENT:

In service, your mission was given to you. Now you choose your own.

I want to be remembered for: _____

The people I want to serve now: _____

My new mission: _____

AREAS TO EXPLORE:

- ? Mentoring younger veterans or at-risk youth
- ? Volunteering with veteran organizations
- ? Education / new career aligned with my values
- ? Creative expression (writing, art, music)
- ? Physical challenges (sports, hiking, fitness goals)
- ? Community building / starting something new

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 1

Dates: _____ to _____

Rate each symptom daily (0=none, 1=mild, 2=moderate, 3=severe):

Symptom	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Nightmares	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Flashbacks	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Avoidance	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Hyperarousal	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Anger/Irritability	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Mood (low)	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Concentration	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Sleep quality	___	___	___	___	___	___	___

WEEKLY TOTAL SCORE: _____ / 168

(Lower is better. Track your progress over time.)

BIGGEST TRIGGER THIS WEEK:

COPING STRATEGY THAT WORKED:

WHAT I'M PROUD OF THIS WEEK:

GOAL FOR NEXT WEEK:

APPOINTMENTS/SUPPORT USED:

? Therapy ? VA visit ? Group ? Battle buddy call ? Exercise

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 2

Dates: _____ to _____

Rate each symptom daily (0=none, 1=mild, 2=moderate, 3=severe):

Symptom	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Nightmares	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Flashbacks	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Avoidance	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Hyperarousal	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Anger/Irritability	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Mood (low)	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Concentration	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Sleep quality	___	___	___	___	___	___	___

WEEKLY TOTAL SCORE: _____ / 168

(Lower is better. Track your progress over time.)

BIGGEST TRIGGER THIS WEEK:

COPING STRATEGY THAT WORKED:

WHAT I'M PROUD OF THIS WEEK:

GOAL FOR NEXT WEEK:

APPOINTMENTS/SUPPORT USED:

? Therapy ? VA visit ? Group ? Battle buddy call ? Exercise

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 3

Dates: _____ to _____

Rate each symptom daily (0=none, 1=mild, 2=moderate, 3=severe):

Symptom	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Nightmares	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Flashbacks	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Avoidance	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Hyperarousal	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Anger/Irritability	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Mood (low)	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Concentration	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Sleep quality	___	___	___	___	___	___	___

WEEKLY TOTAL SCORE: _____ / 168

(Lower is better. Track your progress over time.)

BIGGEST TRIGGER THIS WEEK:

COPING STRATEGY THAT WORKED:

WHAT I'M PROUD OF THIS WEEK:

GOAL FOR NEXT WEEK:

APPOINTMENTS/SUPPORT USED:

? Therapy ? VA visit ? Group ? Battle buddy call ? Exercise

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 4

Dates: _____ to _____

Rate each symptom daily (0=none, 1=mild, 2=moderate, 3=severe):

Symptom	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Nightmares	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Flashbacks	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Avoidance	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Hyperarousal	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Anger/Irritability	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Mood (low)	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Concentration	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Sleep quality	___	___	___	___	___	___	___

WEEKLY TOTAL SCORE: _____ / 168

(Lower is better. Track your progress over time.)

BIGGEST TRIGGER THIS WEEK:

COPING STRATEGY THAT WORKED:

WHAT I'M PROUD OF THIS WEEK:

GOAL FOR NEXT WEEK:

APPOINTMENTS/SUPPORT USED:

? Therapy ? VA visit ? Group ? Battle buddy call ? Exercise

WEEKLY SYMPTOM TRACKER - WEEK 5

Dates: _____ to _____

Rate each symptom daily (0=none, 1=mild, 2=moderate, 3=severe):

Symptom	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Nightmares	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Flashbacks	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Avoidance	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Hyperarousal	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Anger/Irritability	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Mood (low)	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Concentration	___	___	___	___	___	___	___
Sleep quality	___	___	___	___	___	___	___

WEEKLY TOTAL SCORE: _____ / 168

(Lower is better. Track your progress over time.)

BIGGEST TRIGGER THIS WEEK:

COPING STRATEGY THAT WORKED:

WHAT I'M PROUD OF THIS WEEK:

GOAL FOR NEXT WEEK:

APPOINTMENTS/SUPPORT USED:

? Therapy ? VA visit ? Group ? Battle buddy call ? Exercise

VA RESOURCES & CRISIS LINES

VETERANS CRISIS LINE

Call: 988 (Press 1) | Text: 838255 | Chat: VeteransCrisisLine.net

IMMEDIATE CRISIS RESOURCES:

Veterans Crisis Line:	988 (Press 1)
Crisis Text Line:	Text 838255
Military OneSource:	1-800-342-9647
National Suicide Prevention:	988
SAMHSA Helpline:	1-800-662-4357

VA MENTAL HEALTH SERVICES:

- VA PTSD Treatment Programs (CPT, PE, EMDR)
- Vet Centers (community-based counseling)
- VA Telehealth / Video Connect appointments
- VA Whole Health Program
- Residential PTSD treatment programs
- VA Caregiver Support Line: 1-855-260-3274

PEER SUPPORT & COMMUNITY:

- Team Red White & Blue (physical/social activities)
- The Mission Continues (community service)
- Wounded Warrior Project
- Give an Hour (free mental health services)
- Cohen Veterans Network (free/low-cost therapy)
- IAVA (Iraq and Afghanistan Veterans of America)

MY LOCAL VA FACILITY:

Name: _____ Phone: _____
My provider: _____ Next appt: _____

MY RECOVERY COMMITMENT

Recovery is not a sign of weakness. It is the bravest mission you will ever undertake. You survived the battlefield. Now choose to thrive beyond it.

I, _____, commit to my recovery.

I acknowledge that:

- ? PTSD is a wound, not a weakness, and I deserve to heal.
- ? Recovery is not linear - setbacks are part of the process.
- ? Asking for help is a sign of strength, not failure.
- ? I am more than my worst moment in service.
- ? My family and loved ones deserve the best version of me.
- ? I have survived 100% of my worst days so far.

My commitment to myself:

Signed: _____ Date: _____

REMEMBER:

You didn't fight alone overseas.
You don't have to fight alone at home.

If you are in crisis right now:

Veterans Crisis Line: 988 (Press 1)

You are not broken. You are not beyond help. You matter.

RECOVERY JOURNAL

Page 1 of 6

Date: _____

How am I feeling today (0-10)? ____ What happened:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

RECOVERY JOURNAL

Page 2 of 6

Date: _____

How am I feeling today (0-10)? ____ What happened:

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RECOVERY JOURNAL

Page 3 of 6

Date: _____

How am I feeling today (0-10)? ____ What happened:

RECOVERY JOURNAL

Page 4 of 6

Date: _____

How am I feeling today (0-10)? ____ What happened:

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RECOVERY JOURNAL

Page 5 of 6

Date: _____

How am I feeling today (0-10)? ____ What happened:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

RECOVERY JOURNAL

Page 6 of 6

Date: _____

How am I feeling today (0-10)? ____ What happened: